



THAT MAN IS A HEAD TALLER THAN ME. THAT MAY CHANGE

AGUIRRE, THE WRATH OF GOD / 1972

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Adventure

DIRECTOR
Werner Herzog

WRITER
Werner Herzog

STARS
Klaus Kinski, Helena Rojo, Ray Guerra, Del Negro

BEFORE
1968 In *Signs of Life*, Herzog explores how isolation causes a man's madness, a theme he would develop in *Aguirre*.

AFTER
1979 Francis Ford Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* pays homage to *Aguirre* by using "visual quotations" from the movie.
1982 *Fitzcarraldo*, Herzog's second movie about a deluded European in the Amazon, also stars Klaus Kinski.

1987 *Cobra Verde* is Herzog's final work with Kinski as a madman lost to civilization.

Werner Herzog's *Aguirre, the Wrath of God* is one of the most original pieces of cinema ever created. It is based on the doomed 1561 expedition of Spanish conquistador Lope de Aguirre to find El Dorado, the mythical Amazonian city of gold. Herzog's story is of an obsessive quest that descends into madness, driven by a mesmeric performance from Klaus Kinski as Aguirre.

Extreme location

The filming of *Aguirre* has become something of a legend. It was shot in the Peruvian rain forest in a matter of weeks, and the cast and crew endured many of the same

hardships as Aguirre's expedition: climbing mountains, braving rapids on makeshift rafts, and hacking through jungle. Kinski went beyond the confines of "temperamental" into the outright unhinged, regularly raging at Herzog, the crew, and local extras. At one point, he shot off an extra's fingertip.

The fact the movie was even finished is due to Herzog's ability to see possibilities on the spot. He made up much of the dialogue as he went along, and frequently incorporated incidents into the movie that occurred among the extras. Herzog's cinematographer, Thomas Mauch, produced a visually stunning movie, described by a



Werner Herzog Director

Werner Herzog is a director with a singular cinematic vision. Born

in 1942, he grew up in a remote village in Bavaria, Germany. He was a rebel at school, but at 14 he read in an encyclopedia about filmmaking and, as he later admitted, stole a 35mm camera from the Munich Film School.

He made his first feature movie *Signs of Life* in 1968. Four years later, *Aguirre, the Wrath of God*, brought him international fame. He has also made many acclaimed documentaries.

Key movies

1972 *Aguirre, the Wrath of God*
1979 *Nosferatu the Vampire*
1982 *Fitzcarraldo*